The Help - Screenplay

By Tate Taylor (based on the novel by Kathryn Stockett)

Suggested Roles: ***Actress 1:*** *Skeeter, Mae Mobley, Elizabeth Leefolt (Aibileen's employer), Hilly Holbrook (Minny's employer), Bookstore Clerk, Hilly's Mother*
Actress 2: *Aibileen, Minny, Voice Over*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

(Skeeter is on the phone, while Aibileen is tending to her duties – they do not interact)

SKEETER: **(Pg 33)** Miss Stein, you said to write about what disturbs me, particularly if it bothers no one else . . .

AIBILEEN: **(Pg 2)** *(going about her household chores; dusting etc.)* I done raised seventeen kids in my life. Lookin' after white babies, that's what I do . . .

SKEETER: **(Pg 33-34)** I'd like to write something from the point of view of the help. These colored women raise white children, and then in twenty years those children become the boss. We love them and they love us, but they can't even use the toilets in our houses . . .

AIBILEEN: **(Pg 4)** I do all the cooking, cleaning, washing, ironing and grocery shopping, but mostly. . . **(Pg 2)** I know how to get them babies asleep, stop cryin', and go in the toilet bowl before they mommas even get outta bed in the mornin'. *(She wakes up Mae Mobley and cradles her in her arms; affection for the child is clear)*

SKEETER: **(Pg 34)** Margaret Mitchell glorified the mammy figure who dedicates her whole life to a white family but no one. . .ever asked *Mammy* how she felt about it. Nobody ever talks about it down here.

AIBILEEN: **(Pg 3)** Oh, Baby Girl. You is kind. You is smart. You is important. **(Pg 2)** That I know.

MAE MOBLEY: **(Pg 43)** *(Mae Mobley lovingly glides her hand down Aibileen's cheek)* You're my real mama, Aibee.

AIBILEEN: *(Snuggles Mae Mobley)* Baby Girl!

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Three unforgettable women from Jackson Mississippi, circa 1963*
ACTRESS 2: *22-year old Skeeter has just returned home after graduating from Ole Miss.*
ACTRESS 1: *Aibileen, a black maid – wise and regal and Minney, Aibileen's best friend – perhaps the sassiest woman in Mississippi. She can cook like nobody's business.*
ACTRESS 1: *As different from one another as they can be, these women will nonetheless come together for a clandestine project that will put them all at risk. And why?*
ACTRESS 2: *Because they are suffocating within the lines that define their town and their times. And sometimes . . .*
TOGETHER: *. . . lines are made to be crossed and the truth will set you free.*
ACTRESS 1: *The Help Screenplay by Tate Taylor*
ACTRESS 2: *Based on the novel by Kathyrn Stockett*

ELIZABETH: **(Pg 4)** Aibileen, bridge club! **(Pg 13)** The girls are pulling up, and the table isn't set!

AIBILEEN: **(Pg 19)** No, ma'am.

ELIZABETH: **(Pg 4)** Set out the dessert forks, please.

AIBILEEN: **(Pg 19)** Yes, ma'am. *(Aibileen bustles around filling glasses of tea, etc, she exits to the kitchen – Skeeter enters)*

SKEETER: **(Pg 23)** (whispering) Aibileen?

AIBLEEN: **(Pg 45)** [Miss Skeeter], ma'am. Everything okay? *(Aibileen becomes nervous – white ladies don't fraternize with the help)*

SKEETER: Oh, yeah, I just wanted to talk to you. **(Pg 37-38)** I want to interview you . . . about working for white families. . .

AIBILEEN: *(keeping her head down)* You know what'd happen if Miss knew I was tellin' stories on her?

SKEETER: . . . *(oblivious)* To show what y'all get paid, and the babies, and the bathrooms, the good and the bad.

AIBILEEN: **(Pg 45)** They set my cousin's car on fire just cause she went down to the voting station.

SKEETER: I know it's scary

AIBLEEN: I do this with you, I might as well burn my own house down.

SKEETER: *(pleading)* [But . . .] A book like this has never been written before!

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

AIBILEEN: **(Pg 51)** *(gathers herself)* Miss Skeeter, what if you don't like what I got to say? About white peoples?

SKEETER: This isn't about me. It doesn't matter how I feel.

ELIZABETH: *(Enters the kitchen angrily)* **(Pg 21)** Aibileen, Go check on Mae Mobley *(Aibileen rushes off)*

****** Back to bridge club******

HILLY: **(Pg 22-23)** *(in mid conversation to the women at her bridge table; she speaks with "privilege")* . . . If Aibileen uses the guest bath, I'm sure she uses yours too. *(Aibileen enters and begins refilling tea glasses and organizing the snack table – Hilly continues as if she is not there)* It's just plain dangerous. They carry different diseases than we do. *(Aibileen hears reacts non-verbally; out of site of the women)* That's why I've drafted The Home Health Sanitation Initiative. A disease preventative bill that requires every white home to have a separate bathroom for the colored help. *(She gives Aibileen a look and motions for her to refill her cup – before she can do so, Hilly covers her cup and speaks pointedly to Aibileen)* I'll do whatever it takes to protect our children.

****** The next evening – Skeeter is at Aibileen's house******

There is a knock at the kitchen door. Aibileen quickly opens it and waves Skeeter inside.

AIBILEEN: **(Pg 50-51)** Quick. Come in quick.

SKEETER: I parked way up on State Street and caught a cab here like you asked. I know now that it's against the law what we're doin'.

VOICE OVER: **(Pg 47)** From "The Mississippi Code of Conduct for Non-whites" -- Any person printin', publishin' or circulating written matter urgin' for public acceptance of social equality between whites and negroes is subject to imprisonment.

AIBILEEN: **(Pg 51)** You gone have to change my name. Mine, Miss Leefolt's, everbody's.

SKEETER: **(Pg 54)** *(nodding)* You have no idea how much I appreciate your doing this with me. What changed your mind?

AIBILEEN: God. And Miss Hilly Holbrook.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SKEETER: (Pg 1) *(taking out a notebook, she begins the interview)* Did you know as a girl, growing up, that one day you'd be a maid?

AIBILEEN: Yes, ma'am. I did. My momma was a maid. My grandmomma was a house slave.

SKEETER: What does it feel like, to raise a white child when your own child's at home. . . being looked after by somebody else?

AIBILEEN: (Pg 11) *(this is difficult for her)* I lost my own boy, four years ago. *(she begins to cry)* **(Pg 78-79)** They killed my son. He fell carrying two by fours at the mill. Truck run over him, crushed his lungs. *(sadness is overtaken by anger)* That white foreman threw his body on the back of a truck. Drove to the colored hospital and dumped him there and honked the horn. There was nothin' they could do . . . so I brought my baby home. Laid him down on that sofa right there. He died right in front of me. Just twenty-four years old, Miss Skeeter. Best part of a person's life. Anniversary of his death come every year and I can't breathe. But to y'all it's just another day of bridge. *(a quiet silence – Skeeter takes Aibileen's hand)*

MINNY: (Pg 66-68) *(barges through the kitchen door hysterical)* Aibileen! Aibileen! They done set off a bomb in Medgar Evers' carport. *(Minny stops cold in her tracks at the sight of Skeeter- Her face hardens)* Yule May told me what y'all was up to. I didn't wanna believe it. *(Minny storms out the door)*

HILLY: (Pg 42) You are fired, Minny Jackson!

MINNY: *(stops suddenly and re-enters)* **(Pg 67)** All right . . . I'm gone do it. **(Pg 104)** It's time to tell you both "the terrible awful" I did to Miss Hilly. **(Pg 47)** She's done told every white lady in town I'm a thief. Oh, I got her back.

******Flashback to Hilly Holbrook's house*******

MINNY: (Pg 48) *(stands on Hilly's porch holding a chocolate pie – she rings the bell.. Hilly answers the door and Minny presents the pie)* I am sorry.

HILLY: (Pg 104 – 106) *(motions her inside, and speaks while she serves herself up a slice of Minny's famous pie)* So. Nobody wanted to hire a sassmouthin', thievin' nigra, did they? *(Hilly licks her fingers. Minny can barely contain a smile as Hilly swallows another mouthful)* [Chocolate] Pie's as good as always, Minny.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

MINNY: *(Smiling knowingly)* I'm glad you like it

HILLY: *(Taking a large bite of pie, she speaks with her mouth full)* What do you put in here that makes it taste so good?

MINNY: That good vanilla from Mexico. . . And. . . something else real special.

HILLY: *(arrogantly)* If. . . I take you back, I'll have to cut your pay five dollars a week.

MINNY: *(fumes, quickly losing control)* Eat my shit.

HILLY: What did you say?

MINNY: I said Eat . . . My . . . Shit . . .!

HILLY: Have you lost your mind?

MINNY: No, Ma'am. But you're about to, 'cause you just did.

HILLY: Did what? *(Minny nods smugly as she looks down at Hilly's pie. Hilly starts to hyperventilate as everything sinks in. She runs to the kitchen, gagging)*

****** Back in Aibileen's Kitchen*******

Aibileen and Skeeter are speechless. Aibileen looks to Skeeter, shaking her head.

MINNY: (Pg 107) I've done asked God to *forgive* me. But more for what happened to [Hilly's poor mama]. Miss Hilly threw her in that nursing home just for laughing. *(awkward silence, then all break out laughing)*

AIBILEEN: (Pg 104) The world done gone crazy, Miss Skeeter! And I'm scared! What if people find out what we writing? Figure out "Niceville" really Jackson. **(Pg 107)** If people find out "The Terrible Awful" was you and Miss Hilly, we're in trouble there ain't words for!

SKEETER: No, no. That's too dangerous.

MINNY: All right, y'all two brought me into this, but I'm gonna finish it! Either put it in or pull my parts out all together. Y'all pick!

SKEETER: (Pg 116) (thoughtful beat) Well, I have one more story to type before I put it in the mail.

****** 6 months later*******

(Pg 122) *(The display window of a bookstore. A clerk sets down a stack of books beside. She takes one and sets it vertically atop the stack for display)*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

AIBLEEN: **(Pg 125)** There it is!

SKEETER: **(Pg 122)** . . . The Help, by Anonymous.

AIBILEEN: They printed a few thousand copies. **(Pg 123-124)** They sent Miss Skeeter six hundred dollars. She broke the money up and gave it to each of us.

HILLY'S MOTHER: *(reads The Help aloud to a group of women in the nursing home)* "She fired me for using the inside toilet. Put me out in a storm and told me never to come back. But I did come back. I came back with a pie I had baked to say I'm sorry. I watched her eat..." *(She turns a page and suddenly freezes. Reading to herself now, a satisfied smile begins to form)*

****** The next day at the Leefolt Home*******

(Pg 138-140) *(Aibileen enters to find Elizabeth and Hilly staring at her)*

HILLY: Aibileen, the silver I lent Elizabeth last week . . . When you returned it, three pieces were missing.

AIBILEEN: *(flustered)* Lemme . . . lemme go check in the kitchen. Maybe I left some behind.

HILLY: You know as well as I do that silver's not in the kitchen. It behooves me to inform you that you are fired, Aibileen. And I'll be calling the police. Elizabeth can take care of her own children.

AIBILEEN: I didn't steal no silver.

HILLY: Maybe I can't send you to jail for what you wrote, but I can send you for being a thief.

AIBILEEN: *(quickly – she finally stands up for herself)* I know something about you. Don't you forget that. *(Hilly narrows her eyes)* And they's a lot a time to write letters from jail. Plenty of time to write the truth about you.

HILLY: Nobody would believe what you wrote.

AIBILEEN: I don't know. I been told I'm a pretty good writer! Already sold a lot a books!

HILLY: Call the police, Elizabeth.

AIBILEEN: All you do is scare and lie to get what you want. You a godless woman. Ain't you tired, Miss Hilly? Ain't you tired? *(Hilly storms off)*

MAE MOBLEY: **(Pg 141-143)** Don't go Aibee.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

AIBILEEN: I gots to, baby. I am so sorry. I don't want to leave you, but . . . it's time for me to retire. You my last little girl.

MAE MOBLEY: Noooo! *(she cries)*

AIBILEEN: Baby, I need you to remember ever thing I told you. Do you remember?

MAE MOBLEY: You is kind. You is smart. You is important.

AIBILEEN: That's right, Baby Girl. *(Aibileen walks away) (to audience)* Mae Mobley was my last baby. In just ten minutes, the only life I knew was done.

MAE MOBLEY: *(Mae Mobley runs to the living room window crying. She beats on the glass from inside. Aibileen never turns)* Aibeeee! Don't go!

AIBILEEN: God says we need to love our enemies *(long beat)* It hard to do . . . But it can start by telling the truth. No one had ever asked me what it felt like to be me. Once I told the truth about that . . . I felt free.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Tate Taylor; based on the novel by Kathryn Stockett
ISBN: N/A
Publisher: Scriptfly.com
Date (Month/Year): 2011

Cut from this on-line transcript:
https://www.screenwritersnetwork.org/wp-content/uploads/2021/03/The-Help-Script.pdf
****Original Screenplay can be purchased from Scripfly.com***

AWARD HISTORY

2012 National Qualifier
2017 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier- MS
2020 National Qualifier
NCFL Qualifier
NIETOC
IN State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
NE State Qualifier

Find out more about the early 1960s in Mississippi here:
http://eudorawelty.org/wp-content/uploads/2014/12/Early-60s-in-MS-10-17-14.pdf